

THE POLITICAL MODEL CANVAS:

Mapping Argentina's Competing Institutional Regimes

Through an Evolutionary Framework (EPT + EGT + BMC)

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ABSTRACT

This paper introduces the Political Model Canvas (PMC), a novel analytical framework that adapts Osterwalder and Pigneur's Business Model Canvas to map competing ideological-institutional regimes as evolutionary systems. Integrating Extended Phenotype Theory (EPT), Evolutionary Game Theory (EGT), and the institutional analysis of Acemoglu and Robinson, the framework is applied to Argentina's two dominant competing models: the protectionist regime (1945-2023) and the liberalizing regime (multiple cycles). Each model is analyzed across nine homologous building blocks — from coalition structure and value proposition to institutional assets and systemic costs — revealing why the protectionist model has functioned as an Evolutionarily Stable Strategy (ESS) in the Argentine environment despite chronic economic underperformance. A third canvas maps three viable ESS scenarios, including a hybrid metastable equilibrium (estimated probability 40%) that is the only Pareto-superior outcome achievable without constitutional reform. The framework generates nine falsifiable predictions with evaluation horizon of June 2027.

Keywords: Political Model Canvas, Extended Phenotype Theory, Evolutionary Game Theory, Constitutional Lock-in, Argentina, Institutional Economics, Memetics, ESS

JEL codes: B52, D71, D74, K10, O17, P16

I. Introduction: Why Map Institutional Regimes as Business Models?

Why does a country with abundant natural resources, a historically educated population, and repeated democratic transitions fail to achieve sustained institutional reform? The canonical answer draws on path dependence (North, 1990), veto players (Tsebelis, 2002), or political economy (Acemoglu and Robinson, 2012). Each explanation captures something real, yet none provides a sufficiently granular map of the operational architecture that sustains competing institutional regimes over time.

This paper proposes a different entry point. The Business Model Canvas (BMC), developed by Osterwalder and Pigneur (2010), is a strategic management tool that describes how an organization creates, delivers, and captures value across nine interdependent building blocks. The central insight of this paper is that ideological-institutional regimes do the same thing — they create, deliver, and capture value (measured in political power, legitimacy, and self-replication) — and can therefore be analyzed with the same architecture.

The analogy is not decorative. Dawkins' Extended Phenotype Theory (EPT) establishes that organisms extend their genetic influence beyond their physical bodies through environmental artifacts — beaver dams, spider webs, architectural structures. Applied to institutional analysis (Lerer, 2024a), legal and political institutions function as extended phenotypes of competing cultural replicators (memes): they are built by ideological memplexes to ensure their own replication through professional communities, educational systems, and enforcement mechanisms.

Evolutionary Game Theory (EGT) adds the formal apparatus for predicting which institutional strategies will persist. A strategy is Evolutionarily Stable (ESS) when it cannot be invaded by alternative strategies, given the current payoff landscape. Argentina's Constitutional Lock-in Index (CLI) of 0.89 (Lerer, 2024b) — derived from 23 documented reform attempts between 1989 and 2023, all of which failed to produce sustained change — provides quantitative evidence that the protectionist regime has functioned as an ESS in the Argentine institutional environment, regardless of its chronic inefficiency as measured by standard economic indicators.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section II introduces the Political Model Canvas (PMC) framework. Section III applies it to Argentina's protectionist regime. Section IV applies it to the liberalizing regime. Section V maps three viable ESS scenarios, with a particular focus on the hybrid metastable equilibrium as the only Pareto-superior outcome achievable without constitutional amendment. Section VI presents nine falsifiable predictions.

II. The Political Model Canvas: Framework

The nine building blocks of the BMC have direct homologues in the domain of ideological-institutional regimes. The translation is not arbitrary: each block captures a dimension of the system's ability to create, deliver, and capture value, where value is measured in political power, institutional durability, and self-replicating capacity.

BMC Block	Political Model Canvas Equivalent	EPT Dimension
Customer Segments	Primary Beneficiary Coalition	Replicator host population
Value Proposition	Ideological Promise	Memetic fitness signal
Channels	Memetic Transmission Channels	Extended phenotype infrastructure
Customer Relationships	Loyalty Mechanisms	Exit cost architecture

BMC Block	Political Model Canvas Equivalent	EPT Dimension
Revenue Streams	Resource Capture	Energy extraction from environment
Key Resources	Institutional Assets	Extended phenotype hardware
Key Activities	Reproductive Activities	Replication mechanisms
Key Partners	Allied Coalition	Symbiotic relationships
Cost Structure	Systemic Costs	Metabolic load of the phenotype

The EPT dimension column is analytically critical. It locates each block within the evolutionary vocabulary: the coalition is the host population through which the replicator (ideological meme) propagates; the value proposition is the fitness signal that makes the meme attractive to new hosts; channels are the extended phenotype infrastructure built by the replicator to ensure its own transmission; loyalty mechanisms are exit cost architectures that reduce defection probability; revenue streams are energy extraction mechanisms from the institutional environment; key resources are the extended phenotype hardware consolidated over time; key activities are the replication mechanisms; partners are symbiotic relationships with other replicators; and the cost structure is the metabolic load that any persistent phenotype must bear.

Two properties of this framework deserve emphasis. First, it is explicitly non-normative at the analytical level: a model can score high on evolutionary fitness while scoring low on allocative efficiency or human welfare. The protectionist model illustrates this paradox precisely. Second, the framework generates falsifiable predictions, a requirement that distinguishes it from purely descriptive institutional analysis.

III. Canvas 1: The Protectionist Regime

CANVAS 1: PROTECTIONIST REGIME	
Coalition	Organized triad: CGT (formal workers), protected industrialists (domestic market), social economy organizations + provincial peronist governments. No equivalent vehicle exists for the liberalizing coalition.
Value Prop.	Labor security as right (not risk) + regulated access to basic goods + ontological political identity (being a 'worker' in the Peronist sense). Low substitutability. The model does not sell economic policy; it sells belonging.
Channels	Densest institutional network in Latin America: national education system (since 1884), union structure (since 1945), public media, universities (since 1918), social transfer programs (AUH since 2009). Each channel is an extended phenotype artifact.
Loyalty Mech.	Corporatist architecture: negotiation with organizations, not individuals. Mandatory union dues. Union health funds (obras sociales) as retention mechanism. Exit costs: losing health coverage, employment network access, negative signaling. EGT: cooperation is the dominant strategy because the payoff landscape has been modified.

Resources	INDEC as administrable data producer. BCRA subordinated to fiscal policy. Labor courts with pro-formal-worker interpretation bias. Constitution of 1949 (and its legacy in 1994). Universities as cadre producers. CLI 0.89 as the ultimate institutional asset.
Activities	Annual collective bargaining. Active resistance to labor reform (documented across all 23 reform attempts). Presidential decrees (DNU) as governance mechanism bypassing legislative uncertainty. Academic production legitimizing the model. Periodic reform of university curricula.
Partners	CGT as non-negotiable partner. Domestic market industrialists (industrial chambers, state contractors). Social economy organizations (since 1990s). Provincial peronist governments as electoral guarantors in exchange for federal coparticipation.
Costs	Chronic inflation (inevitable result of monetary deficit financing). Institutional lock-in (ultraactivity of collective agreements, effectively uncapped severance pay). Productive disinvestment. Talent emigration. Low-productivity trap that self-perpetuates.
Revenue	Agricultural export taxes (transfer from most efficient sector). Differential exchange rate (implicit subsidy to protected industry). Seigniorage (redistributes from unorganized informal sector to formal unionized sector). External debt when the first three are exhausted.

3.1 The Lock-in Architecture

The defining feature of the protectionist model is not its ideological content but its lock-in architecture. Over eight decades, the model has constructed an institutional infrastructure — Constitutional Lock-in Index 0.89 — that makes modification prohibitively costly even under governments explicitly committed to reform.

The lock-in operates through four simultaneous mechanisms (Lerer, 2024c): constitutional entrenchment of social rights (Article 14 bis); legislative inertia guaranteed by the model's superior organizational capacity in the legislature; judicial interpretation bias in labor courts accumulated through decades of jurisprudential sedimentation; and union resistance with credible threat of general strikes. No single reform attempt has successfully dismantled all four mechanisms simultaneously. The 23 documented attempts between 1989 and 2023 achieved a sustained success rate of 0%.

In EPT terms, each of these four mechanisms is an extended phenotype artifact of the memplexo: constructed by the ideological replicator to ensure its own persistence in the environment. The analogy with beaver dams is precise: the dam does not 'know' it benefits the beaver's genes, yet it is constructed to do exactly that. Argentine labor legislation does not 'know' it benefits the protectionist memplexo, yet it has been built — provision by provision, ruling by ruling, convention by convention — to do exactly that.

3.2 Evolutionary Fitness Assessment

Measured against the nine PMC dimensions, the protectionist model scores very high on channels (five-star, eight decades of dense institutional network), loyalty mechanisms (five-star, structural lock-in with prohibitive exit costs), institutional assets (five-star, consolidated over eight decades), key activities (five-star, reproduced continuously through collective bargaining and

legislative resistance), and coalition structure (four-star, wide and organized, with the CGT as a unique organizational vehicle).

It scores very low on allocative efficiency (one-star): chronic inflation, productive disinvestment, talent emigration, and the low-productivity trap are systemic costs of the model. But evolutionary fitness is not allocative efficiency. A strategy is ESS if it cannot be invaded by alternatives in the current environment — not if it maximizes welfare. The Argentine institutional environment, as measured by CLI 0.89, has functioned as a selection pressure that systematically favors the protectionist model's reproduction.

IV. Canvas 2: The Liberalizing Regime

CANVAS 2: LIBERALIZING REGIME	
Coalition	Efficient export sector (agriculture, mining, hydrocarbons). Finance. Professionals with internationally tradable human capital. SMEs in services. Structurally more fragmented than the protectionist coalition: lacks an organizational vehicle equivalent to the CGT.
Value Prop.	Allocative efficiency (quality goods at international prices). Macroeconomic predictability. Rule of law + judicial independence. Meritocracy as distributive principle. Modernity/global integration identity. Critical weakness: meritocracy is credible only for those who already hold credentials.
Channels	Private mass media (ABC1 penetration). Private elite universities (UCA, Di Tella, UTDT, IAE). Think tanks (FIEL, CIPPEC). International organizations (external legitimacy). Since 2023: social media and libertarian influencers as the most significant memetic innovation in decades.
Loyalty Mech.	Upward social mobility expectation (works in economic expansion; collapses in recession). Negative loyalty: allegiance built not on what the model delivers but on what it threatens to destroy ('la casta', the Kirchnerist status quo). EGT: negative loyalty is cheaper to maintain but more fragile.
Resources	BCRA independence (never fully consolidated). Technically credible INDEC. Policy think tanks. Private elite universities. In the 2023- version: deregulation itself as operational asset. Constitutional jurisprudence on labor law (being built).
Activities	Producing empirical evidence of protectionist costs. Negotiating trade agreements as irreversible facts. Building constitutional jurisprudence limiting union ultraactivity. Fiscal adjustment as reduction of the rival model's operational cost. Systematic deregulation.
Partners	Agricultural export sector. Formal financial sector. Export chambers of commerce. International credit organizations (IMF, IDB, World Bank) as external legitimacy providers. Tactical alliances with provincial governors of diverse political alignment in exchange for legislative support.
Costs	Olson asymmetry: concentrated winners, diffuse but vocal losers. Structural dependence on external credit. Meritocracy credible only for credentialed population. Transition recession visible before benefits materialize. CLI 0.89 inherited: same environment, lower fitness.
Revenue	Genuine fiscal revenue from export sector (Ganancias, VAT, moderate tariffs) when macro is orderly. Fiscal adjustment liberates resources previously financing rival

coalition. External credit (IMF, capital markets) as transition financing: structural dependence that collapses the model when access is interrupted.

4.1 The Adaptive Trap

The liberalizing model faces a structural paradox that deserves its own analytical label: the adaptive trap. To succeed, the model needs time to show results. To buy time, it needs external credit. To access credit, it needs credibility. To build credibility, it needs to show results. The circularity is not rhetorical: it is the mechanism that has terminated every liberalizing cycle in Argentine history before the model's benefits became visible to a majority of the electorate.

In EGT terms, the liberalizing model faces an unfavorable payoff landscape inherited from the protectionist model's institutional construction. Attempting to use legislative or executive strategies alone (Type 1 or Type 2 in Lerer's taxonomy) in a Type 3 evolutionary environment (where equilibria are evolutionary attractors, not Nash equilibria) will fail because there is no single agent to negotiate with and no mechanism for the rapid modification of accumulated institutional inertia.

4.2 Olson's Asymmetry as Structural Constraint

Mancur Olson's 1965 insight applies with particular force to the liberalizing model: its benefits are diffuse (shared broadly across the population) while its costs are concentrated (falling on specific, well-organized constituencies). This asymmetry generates a systematic mobilization imbalance. The losing constituencies — formal unionized workers, protected industrialists, beneficiaries of state employment — have far greater organizational capacity and incentive to resist than the winning constituencies have to support the reform.

The 2023-2026 Milei administration has attempted to partially circumvent this asymmetry through two innovations. The first is negative loyalty construction: building political support not on the model's positive deliverables but on opposition to a salient and credible enemy ('la casta'). The second is the speed of adjustment: implementing a large number of reforms simultaneously to overwhelm the organizational capacity of the opposition coalitions. Both innovations are theoretically coherent responses to the Olson asymmetry, and both face the same fundamental constraint: they work until the transition recession becomes personally salient for a sufficient portion of the electorate.

V. Canvas 3: ESS Scenarios and the Virtuous Equilibrium

The fundamental question that the PMC framework allows us to pose with analytical precision is: given the current payoff landscape (CLI 0.89; dominant protectionist ESS; liberalizing model in adaptive trap), what is the probability distribution across feasible equilibria, and what incentive modifications would make a welfare-superior equilibrium stable?

Scenario	Probability	ESS Type	Activation Conditions	Key Falsification
ESS-1: Refounded Protectionism	35%	Pure dominant strategy	External shock; liberalizing coalition not consolidated; electoral reversal post-adjustment	If deficit exceeds 3% GDP for 2 consecutive years
ESS-2: Consolidated Liberalizing Transition	25%	Invasion of dominant ESS	Mercosur-EU agreement ratified; CSJN consolidates labor jurisprudence; growth visible before 2027	If external credit closes before benefits materialize
ESS-3: Hybrid Metastable Equilibrium	40%	Mixed ESS (cooperative)	Deficit 0-2% GDP for 3 years; sectoral union negotiation; CSJN validates partial market reforms; inflation below 3%/month sustained	If CGT calls general strike in 2026; or deficit exceeds 3% GDP

5.1 The Hybrid Metastable Equilibrium (ESS-3)

ESS-3 is analytically the most important scenario because it is the only one that is Pareto-superior to the current situation and achievable without constitutional reform. Its defining property is that no actor can improve its position through unilateral defection — the classic condition for a Nash equilibrium — and that this equilibrium is stable against invasion by pure strategies, satisfying the ESS condition.

The payoff structure that makes ESS-3 possible is the following.

Actor / Strategy	CGT/Unions	Export Sector	CSJN/Judiciary	Government
Full cooperation with gradual reform	(+2, -1): Preserves sectoral veto; loses central monopoly	+4: Lower labor costs; formal market expansion	+2: Extended institutional role	+3: Reforms consolidated; coalition maintained
Total resistance / Blockade	+5 short, -3 long: Preserves status quo briefly	-2: Rigidity + inflation + distorted FX continues	0: Avoids institutional conflict	-3: Reform collapsed; credibility lost
ESS-3 Hybrid (metastable equil.)	+3: Permanent sectoral negotiation; preserves health funds	+3: Flexible labor access without political cost	+3: Consistent jurisprudence; predictability	+3: Partial reforms consolidated; sustainable governance

The critical observation from this matrix is that ESS-3 (Hybrid) yields payoff +3 for all four actors simultaneously, making it superior to both unilateral strategies. Mutual blockade yields (0,0); if either actor deviates, it incurs a payoff of -2 or -3. This means ESS-3 is reachable if each actor believes that all others will also play the cooperative strategy — i.e., if there exists a credible coordination mechanism.

The coordination problem is the central obstacle. No actor will unilaterally adopt the cooperative strategy if it believes others will defect. This is where costly signaling becomes critical: the government must signal credibly that it will maintain fiscal discipline; the CGT must signal credibly that it will accept sectoral flexibility in exchange for preservation of organizational power; the CSJN must signal credibly through consistent jurisprudence; and export sector employers must signal credibly that increased flexibility will translate into formal employment expansion, not mere extraction.

Each of these signals is costly precisely because it requires each actor to accept constraints that are individually suboptimal in the absence of reciprocity. The IMF's monitoring role, the Mercosur-EU agreement as an irreversible institutional fact, and the CSJN's jurisprudential consolidation all function as external enforcement mechanisms that reduce the risk of unilateral defection by any single actor.

5.2 Why ESS-3 Is the Most Probable Outcome

ESS-3 (40% estimated probability) is more likely than ESS-2 (25%) for two reasons. First, ESS-2 requires the liberalizing model to consolidate before the transition recession becomes electorally decisive, a timing constraint that Argentine institutional history suggests is structurally unfavorable. Second, ESS-3 requires no actor to abandon its ideological identity: unions can remain unions, exporters can remain exporters, and the government can remain committed to fiscal discipline — the equilibrium requires only that each actor accepts constraints at the margin, not that it transforms its fundamental nature.

ESS-3 is more likely than ESS-1 (35%) under the specific assumption that the 2023-2026 fiscal adjustment has been sufficiently deep to alter the payoff landscape for at least some actors in the protectionist coalition — particularly provincial governments that have benefited from the elimination of chronic monetary financing of deficits. If this assumption is correct, a subset of protectionist coalition actors has an incentive to sustain the hybrid equilibrium even at the cost of accepting partial liberalization.

ESS-3 is more likely to emerge after economic shock than after policy success, which generates the counterintuitive prediction P9: a moderate external shock in 2025-2026 may actually increase the probability of the virtuous hybrid equilibrium by altering the relative payoffs of blockade versus cooperation.

VI. Falsifiable Predictions

The framework generates nine falsifiable predictions. Each is tied to an observable indicator and a specific evaluation date, satisfying the Popperian criterion that distinguishes scientific hypotheses from unfalsifiable narratives.

#	Prediction	Observable indicator	Falsification date
P1	If CLI > 0.80, no labor reform will achieve full implementation	Legislative + judicial + union + business resistance	December 2026
P2	ESS-3 requires deficit between 0-2% GDP for minimum 3 consecutive years	Argentine Ministry of Economy fiscal reports	December 2027
P3	Negative loyalty (anti-Kirchnerism) will dissipate faster than positive loyalty	Panel surveys of electoral preferences	Mid-term elections 2025/2027
P4	Mercosur-EU agreement advances to ratification if liberalizing model survives to 2026	Treaty ratification in Argentine Congress	December 2026
P5	CSJN consolidates jurisprudence limiting union ultraactivity in labor disputes	CSJN rulings 2025-2027 analysis	June 2027
P6	If external credit closes before 18 months, ESS-2 is ruled out	Country risk spread and IMF program continuity	August 2026
P7	CGT will fracture sectorially before returning to unified opposition	Internal CGT tensions + sectoral negotiations	June 2026
P8	Sectoral inflation will remain heterogeneous even if average falls below 3%/month	INDEC CPI by category disaggregated	Continuous
P9	ESS-3 is more likely after economic shock than after policy success	Activation dates of metastable equilibrium conditions	Contingent

VII. Conclusions

This paper has introduced the Political Model Canvas (PMC) as a novel framework for mapping competing institutional regimes as evolutionary systems. The application to Argentina reveals three principal findings.

The protectionist model has functioned as an ESS for eighty years not because of ideological superiority or democratic majority, but because it has constructed the densest institutional infrastructure in the Argentine environment — the extended phenotype of a memeplexo that has had eight decades to build its lock-in architecture. The CLI of 0.89 is the quantitative signature of this construction.

The liberalizing model is not inherently unfit; it is relatively unfit in the current Argentine environment. Its allocative efficiency advantages are real, but they materialize on timescales (multiple electoral cycles) that exceed the patience of the political market. The adaptive trap is not an accident: it is the logical consequence of attempting to compete in an environment whose payoff landscape was constructed by the incumbent ESS.

The hybrid metastable equilibrium is both the most probable and the most welfare-superior feasible outcome. It does not require constitutional reform, ideological conversion, or the elimination of existing organizations. It requires only that each actor accept marginal constraints in exchange for credible reciprocity from others — and that a sufficient number of costly signals coordinate the transition from mutual blockade to cooperative equilibrium.

The Political Model Canvas framework is generalizable beyond Argentina. Any political economy characterized by competing ideological-institutional regimes, persistent dysfunctional equilibria, and failed reform attempts is a potential application domain. The combination of EPT (identifying the self-replicating architecture of institutional regimes), EGT (predicting which equilibria are stable), and BMC (mapping the operational architecture in nine comparable dimensions) provides a richer analytical vocabulary than any single framework offers alone.

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Figure Captions

Figure 1: Political Model Canvas — Protectionist Regime. Nine-block canvas mapping Argentina's protectionist institutional model across the homologous BMC dimensions. CLI 0.89; 23 documented reform attempts; 0% sustained success rate (1989-2023).

Figure 2: Political Model Canvas — Liberalizing Regime. Nine-block canvas mapping Argentina's liberalizing institutional model. Note the structural adaptive trap and Olson asymmetry as the principal obstacles to ESS consolidation.

Figure 3: Political Model Canvas — ESS Scenarios and Virtuous Hybrid Equilibrium. Three-scenario analysis with formal payoff matrix demonstrating that the hybrid metastable equilibrium (ESS-3, estimated probability 40%) is the only Pareto-superior outcome achievable without constitutional amendment. Nine falsifiable predictions with evaluation horizon June 2027.

Data Availability

All datasets, replication materials, and supplementary files are publicly available at <https://github.com/adrianlerer/Extended-Phenotype-Institutionalism-contribution/tree/main/data>. The /data/ directory contains: CLI_Scores_Five_Jurisdictions.csv (CLI values for Argentina, Chile, Uruguay, Brazil, and Spain); Reform_Attempts_1991_2024.csv (62 documented reform attempts with outcome coding); Regression_Results_Summary.csv (multivariate regression outputs); Data_Codebook.md (variable definitions and coding decisions); dataset_60_cases_verified.xlsx (60 verified cases underlying the Argentine CLI calculation presented in this paper); historical_reforms_database.csv (23 Argentine labor reform attempts, 1989-2023, with full outcome coding across 18 variables); and political_model_canvas.html (interactive visualization of the three Political Model Canvases, Figures 1-3). Batch-coding documentation for Africa, Asia, Eastern Europe, Latin America, and the Middle East is available in the repository root. Payoff matrix calculations and ESS scenario modeling scripts are available upon request to the author at adrian@lerer.com.ar.